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This article is about the beverage made from Camellia sinensis.

Tea is an [aromatic beverage](#) prepared by pouring hot or [boiling water](#) over [cured](#) or fresh leaves of *[Camellia sinensis](#)*, an [evergreen shrub](#) native to [East Asia](#) which originated in the borderlands of [south-western China](#), [north-east India](#) and [northern Myanmar](#).^{[3][4][5]} Tea is also made, but rarely, from the leaves of *[Camellia taliensis](#)*.^{[6][7][8]} After plain [water](#), tea is the most widely consumed drink in the world.^[9] There are many types of tea; some have a cooling, slightly bitter, and [astringent](#) flavour, while others have profiles that include sweet, nutty, floral, or grassy [notes](#).^[10] Tea has a [stimulating](#) effect in humans, primarily due to its [caffeine](#) content.^[11]

An early credible record of tea drinking dates to the third century AD, in a medical text written by Chinese physician [Hua Tuo](#).^[12] It was popularised as a recreational drink during the Chinese [Tang dynasty](#), and tea drinking spread to other East Asian countries. [Portuguese priests](#) and merchants introduced it to Europe during the 16th century.^[13] During the 17th century, drinking tea became fashionable among the British, who later started to plant tea on a large scale in [India](#), where it had previously been used only as a medicine.

The term [herbal tea](#) refers to drinks not made from *Camellia sinensis*. They are the infusions of fruit, leaves, or [other plant parts](#), such as [steeps](#) of [rosehip](#), [chamomile](#), or [rooibos](#). These may be called *tisanes* or *herbal infusions* to prevent confusion with tea made from the tea plant.

Etymology

The [etymology](#) of the various words for *tea* reflects the history of transmission of tea drinking and trade from China.^[14] Nearly all of the words for tea worldwide fall into three broad groups: *te*, *cha* and *chai*, present in English as *tea*, *cha* or *char*, and *chai*. The earliest of the three to enter English is *cha*, which came in the 1590s via the Portuguese, who traded in [Macao](#) and picked up the [Cantonese](#) pronunciation of the word.^{[15][16]} The more common *tea* form arrived in the 17th century via the Dutch, who acquired it either indirectly from the Malay *teh*, or directly from the *tê* pronunciation in [Min Chinese](#).^[15] The third form *chai* (meaning "spiced tea") originated from a northern

Chinese pronunciation of *cha*, which travelled overland to Central Asia and [Persia](#) where it picked up a Persian ending *yi*. The Chinese word for tea itself was perhaps derived from the non-Sinitic languages of the botanical homeland of the tea plant in south-west China (or [Burma](#)), possibly from an archaic [Austro-Asiatic](#) root word **la*, meaning "leaf".^[17]

Origin and history

Botanical origin

Tea plants are native to East Asia and the probable center of origin of tea is near the source of the [Irrawaddy River](#) from where it spread out fan-wise into southeast China, Indo-China and [Assam](#). The natural home of the tea plant is considered to be within the comparatively small fan-shaped area between [Nagaland](#), [Manipur](#) and [Mizoram](#) along the [Burma](#) frontier in the west, through [China](#) as far as the [Zhejiang](#) Province in the east, and from this line generally south through the hills to Burma and [Thailand](#) to [Vietnam](#). The west–east axis indicated above is about 2,400 km long extending from longitude 95°–120°E. The north–south axis covers about 1,920 km, starting from the northern part of Burma, latitude 29°N passing through [Yunnan](#), [Tongkin](#), Thailand, [Laos](#) and on to Annam, reaching latitude 11°N.^[18]

Chinese (small-leaf) type tea (*C. sinensis* var. *sinensis*) may have originated in southern China possibly with hybridization of unknown wild tea relatives. Since there are no known wild populations of this tea, its origin is speculative.^{[19][20]}

Given their genetic differences forming distinct [clades](#), Chinese Assam-type tea (*C. sinensis* var. *assamica*) may have two parentages – one being found in southern [Yunnan](#) ([Xishuangbanna](#), [Pu'er City](#)) and the other in western Yunnan ([Lincang](#), [Baoshan](#)). Many types of Southern Yunnan Assam tea have been hybridized with the closely related species [Camellia taliensis](#). Unlike Southern Yunnan Assam tea, Western Yunnan Assam tea shares many genetic similarities with Indian Assam-type tea (also *C. sinensis* var. *assamica*). Thus, Western Yunnan Assam tea and Indian Assam tea both may have originated from the same parent plant in the area where southwestern China, Indo-Burma, and Tibet meet. However, as the Indian Assam tea shares no [haplotypes](#) with Western Yunnan Assam tea, Indian Assam tea is likely to have originated from an independent domestication. Some Indian Assam tea appears to have hybridized with the species [Camellia pubicosta](#).^{[19][20]}

Assuming a generation of 12 years, Chinese small-leaf tea is estimated to have diverged from Assam tea around 22,000 years ago, while Chinese Assam tea and Indian Assam tea diverged 2,800 years ago. The divergence of Chinese small-leaf tea and Assam tea would correspond to the last [glacial maximum](#).^{[19][20]}

Early tea drinking

People in ancient East Asia ate tea for centuries, perhaps even [millennia](#), before ever consuming it as a beverage. They would nibble on the leaves raw, add them to [soups](#) or [greens](#), or [ferment](#) them and chew them as [areca nut](#) is [chewed](#).^[22]

Tea drinking may have begun in the region of [Yunnan](#), where it was used for medicinal purposes. It is believed that in [Sichuan](#), "people began to boil tea leaves for consumption into a concentrated liquid without the addition of other leaves or herbs, thereby using tea as a bitter yet stimulating drink, rather than as a medicinal concoction."^[5]

Chinese legends attribute the invention of tea to the mythical [Shennong](#) (in central and northern China) in 2737 BC, although evidence suggests that tea drinking may have been introduced from southwest China.^[21] The earliest written records of tea come from China. The word *tú* 荼 appears in the [Shijing](#) and other ancient texts to signify a kind of "bitter vegetable" (苦菜), and it is possible that it referred to many different plants such as [sow thistle](#), [chicory](#), or [smartweed](#),^[23] as well as tea.^[24] In the [Chronicles of Huayang](#), it was recorded that the [Ba](#) people in Sichuan presented *tu* to the [Zhou](#) king. The [Qin](#) later conquered the state of [Ba](#) and its neighbour [Shu](#), and according to the 17th century scholar [Gu Yanwu](#) who wrote in *Ri Zhi Lu* (日知錄): "It was after the Qin had taken Shu that they learned how to drink tea."^[2] Another possible early reference to tea is found in a letter written by the [Qin dynasty](#) general Liu Kun who requested that some "real tea" to be sent to him.^[25]

The earliest known physical evidence^[26] of tea was discovered in 2016 in the mausoleum of [Emperor Jing of Han](#) in [Xi'an](#), indicating that tea from the genus *Camellia* was drunk by [Han dynasty](#) emperors as early as the second century BC.^[27] The Han dynasty work "The Contract for a Youth", written by [Wang Bao](#) in 59 BC,^[28] contains the first known reference to boiling tea. Among the tasks listed to be undertaken by the youth, the contract states that "he shall boil tea and fill the utensils" and "he shall buy

tea at Wuyang".^[2] The first record of tea cultivation is dated to this period, during which tea was cultivated on Meng Mountain (蒙山) near [Chengdu](#).^[29] Another early credible record of tea drinking dates to the 3rd century AD, in a medical text by the Chinese physician [Hua Tuo](#), who stated, "to drink bitter t'u constantly makes one think better."^[30] However, before the [Tang dynasty](#), tea-drinking was primarily a southern Chinese practice centered in [Jiankang](#).^[31] Tea was disdained by the [Northern dynasties](#) aristocrats, who describe it as inferior to yogurt.^{[32][33]} It became widely popular during the Tang dynasty, when it spread to Korea, [Japan](#), and Vietnam. *The Classic of Tea*, a treatise on tea and its preparations, was written by the 8th century Chinese writer, [Lu Yu](#). The current Chinese word for tea (茶) appeared in *The Classic of Tea* by removing a stroke from the word *tu*.^[34] Lu was known to have influenced tea drinking on a large part in China.^[35]

Developments

Through the centuries, a variety of techniques for processing tea, and a number of different forms of tea, were developed. During the Han and [Six Dynasties](#), tea was steamed and pounded, shaped into cake form, slowly dried over low fire, and suspended to air dry. Chunks of tea were then boiled to drink, flavoured with orange peels, [jujube](#), mint, ginger or [scallion](#).^[36] Tea was similarly prepared in cake form during the Tang dynasty, but [Lu Yu](#) disparaged the use of various condiments to flavour the tea apart from salt.^[37] By the [Song dynasty](#), loose-leaf tea was developed and became popular. During the [Yuan](#) and [Ming](#) dynasties, unoxidized tea leaves were first stirred in a hot dry pan, then rolled and air-dried, a process that stops the [oxidation](#) process that would have turned the leaves dark, thereby allowing tea to remain green. In the 15th century, [oolong](#) tea, in which the leaves are allowed to partially oxidize before being heated in the pan, was developed.^[31] Western tastes, however, favoured the fully oxidized [black tea](#), and the leaves were allowed to oxidize further. [Yellow tea](#) was an accidental discovery in the production of green tea during the Ming dynasty, when apparently careless practices allowed the leaves to turn yellow, which yielded a different flavour.^[38]

Worldwide spread

Tea was first introduced to Western priests and merchants in China during the 16th century, at which time it was termed *chá*.^[13] The earliest European reference to tea, written as *chiai*, came from *Delle navigationi e viaggi* written by Venetian [Giambattista Ramusio](#) in 1545.^[39] The first recorded shipment of tea by a European nation was in 1607 when the Dutch East India Company moved a cargo of tea from [Macao](#) to Java, then two years later, the Dutch bought the first assignment of tea which was from [Hirado](#) in Japan to be shipped to Europe.^[40] Tea became a fashionable drink in [The Hague](#) in the Netherlands, and the Dutch introduced the drink to [Germany](#), [France](#), and across the Atlantic to [New Amsterdam](#) (New York).^[41]

In 1567, Russian people came in contact with tea when [Cossack](#) leaders ([atamans](#)) [Petrov](#) and [Yalyshev](#) visited China.^[42] The Mongolian Khan donated to [Tsar Michael I](#) four [poods](#) (65–70 kg) of tea in 1638.^[43] According to [Jeremiah Curtin](#),^[44] it was possibly in 1636^[45] that [Vassili Starkov](#) was sent as envoy to the [Altyn Khan](#). He was given 250 pounds of tea as a gift to the tsar. Starkov at first refused, seeing no use for a load of dead leaves, but the Khan insisted. Thus was tea introduced to Russia. In 1679, Russia concluded a treaty on regular tea supplies from China via [camel caravan](#) in exchange for furs. It is today considered the *de facto* national beverage.

The first record of tea in English came from a letter written by [Richard Wickham](#), who ran an [East India Company](#) office in Japan, writing to a merchant in [Macao](#) requesting "the best sort of chaw" in 1615. [Peter Mundy](#), a traveller and merchant who came across tea in [Fujian](#) in 1637, wrote, "*chaa* – only water with a kind of herb boyled in it".^{[46][47]} Tea was sold in a coffee house in London in 1657, [Samuel Pepys](#) tasted tea in 1660, and [Catherine of Braganza](#) took the tea-drinking habit to the English court when she married [Charles II](#) in 1662. Tea, however, was not widely consumed in the British Isles until the 18th century and remained expensive until the latter part of that period. English drinkers preferred to add sugar and milk to black tea, and black tea overtook green tea in popularity in the 1720s.^[48] Tea smuggling during the 18th century led to the general public being able to afford and consume tea. The British government removed the tax on tea, thereby eliminating the smuggling trade, by 1785.^[49] In Britain and Ireland, tea was initially consumed as a luxury item on special occasions, such as religious festivals, wakes, and domestic work gatherings. The price of tea in Europe fell steadily during the 19th century, especially after Indian tea began to arrive in large quantities; by the late 19th century tea had become an everyday beverage for all levels of society.^[50] The popularity of tea played a role in historical events – the [Tea Act](#) of 1773 provoked the [Boston Tea Party](#) that escalated into the [American Revolution](#). The

need to address the issue of British trade deficit because of the trade in tea resulted in the [Opium Wars](#). The Qing [Kangxi Emperor](#) had banned foreign products from being sold in China, decreeing in 1685 that all goods bought from China must be paid for in silver coin or bullion.^[51] Traders from other nations then sought to find another product, in this case opium, to sell to China to earn back the silver they were required to pay for tea and other commodities. The subsequent attempts by the Chinese Government to curtail the trade in opium led to war.^[52]

Chinese small-leaf-type tea was introduced into India in 1836 by the British in an attempt to break the Chinese monopoly on tea.^[53] In 1841, [Archibald Campbell](#) brought seeds of [Chinese tea](#) from the [Kumaun](#) region and experimented with planting tea in [Darjeeling](#). The Alubari [tea garden](#) was opened in 1856, and [Darjeeling tea](#) began to be produced.^[54] In 1848, [Robert Fortune](#) was sent by the [East India Company](#) on a mission to China to bring the tea plant back to Great Britain. He began his journey in high secrecy as his mission occurred in the lull between the [First Opium War](#) and the [Second Opium War](#).^[55] The Chinese tea plants he brought back were introduced to the [Himalayas](#), though most did not survive. The British had discovered that a different variety of tea was endemic to [Assam](#) and the northeast region of India, which was then hybridized with Chinese small-leaf-type tea. Using Chinese planting and cultivation techniques, the British colonial government established a tea industry by offering land in Assam to any European who agreed to cultivate it for export.^[53] Tea was originally consumed only by [Anglo-Indians](#); however, it became widely popular in India in the 1950s because of a successful advertising campaign by the India Tea Board.^[53] The British introduced tea industry to Sri Lanka (then Ceylon) in 1867.^[56]

Chemical composition

Physically speaking, tea has properties of both a [solution](#) and a [suspension](#). It is a solution of the water-soluble compounds extracted from the tea leaves, such as the polyphenols and amino acids. Tea infusions are among most consumed beverages globally.^[57]

[Caffeine](#) makes up about 3% of tea's dry weight, which translates to between 30 and 90 milligrams per 250-millilitre (8+¹/₂ US fl oz) cup depending on the type, brand,^[58] and brewing method.^[59] A study found that the caffeine content of one gram of black tea

ranged from 22 to 28 mg, while the caffeine content of one gram of green tea ranged from 11 to 20 mg, reflecting a significant difference.^[60] Tea contains small amounts of [theobromine](#) and [theophylline](#), which are [xanthines](#) and [stimulants](#), similar to caffeine.^[61]

The [astringency](#) in tea can be attributed to the presence of [polyphenols](#). These are the most abundant compounds in tea leaves, making up 30–40% of their composition.^[62] Polyphenols in tea include [flavonoids](#), [epigallocatechin gallate](#) (EGCG), and other [catechins](#).^{[63][64]} Although there has been preliminary [clinical research](#) on whether green or black teas may protect against various human diseases, there is no evidence that tea polyphenols have any effect on health or lowering disease risk.^{[65][66]}

Health effects

Although health benefits have been assumed throughout the history of [Camellia sinensis's](#) consumption, there is no high-quality evidence showing that tea consumption gives significant benefits other than possibly increasing alertness, an effect caused by [caffeine](#) in the tea leaves.^{[67][65]} In [clinical research](#) conducted in the early 21st century, it was found there is no scientific evidence to indicate that consuming tea affects any disease or improves health.^[67]

Black and green teas contain no [essential nutrients](#) in significant amounts, with the exception of the [dietary mineral manganese](#), at 0.5 mg per cup or 26% of the [Reference Daily Intake](#) (RDI).^[68] [Fluoride](#) is sometimes present in tea; certain types of "brick tea", made from old leaves and stems, have the highest levels, enough to pose a health risk if too much tea is drunk, which has been attributed to high levels of fluoride in soils, acidic soils, and long brewing.^[69]

Cultivation and harvesting

Camellia sinensis is an evergreen plant that grows mainly in [tropical](#) and [subtropical](#) climates.^[70] Some varieties can tolerate [oceanic climates](#) and are cultivated as far north as [Cornwall](#) in England,^[71] [Perthshire](#) in Scotland,^[citation needed] [Washington](#) in the

United States,^[72] and Vancouver Island in Canada.^[73] In the Southern Hemisphere, tea is grown as far south as Hobart in Tasmania^{[74][75]} and Waikato in New Zealand.^[76]

Tea plants are propagated from seed and cuttings; about 4 to 12 years are needed for a plant to bear seed and about three years before a new plant is ready for harvesting.^[70] In addition to a zone 8 climate or warmer, tea plants require at least 1,200 millimetres (47 in) of rainfall per year and prefer acidic soils.^[77] Many high-quality tea plants are cultivated at elevations of up to 2,000 metres (6,600 ft) above sea level. Though at these heights the plants grow more slowly, they acquire a better flavour.^[78]

Two principal varieties are used: *Camellia sinensis* var. *sinensis*, which is used for most Chinese, Formosan and Japanese teas, and *C. sinensis* var. *assamica*, used in Pu-erh and most Indian teas (but not Darjeeling). Within these botanical varieties, many strains and modern clonal varieties are known. Leaf size is the chief criterion for the classification of tea plants, with three primary classifications being:^[79] Assam type, characterised by the largest leaves; China type, characterised by the smallest leaves; and Cambodian type, characterised by leaves of intermediate size. The Cambodian-type tea (*C. assamica* subsp. *lasiocalyx*) was originally considered a type of Assam tea. However, later genetic work showed that it is a hybrid between Chinese small-leaf tea and Assam-type large-leaf tea.^[80] Darjeeling tea appears to be another hybrid of the same sort.^[20]

A tea plant will grow into a tree of up to 16 m (52 ft) if left undisturbed,^[70] but cultivated plants are generally pruned to waist height for ease of harvesting. The short plants also bear more new shoots which provide new and tender leaves and increase the quality of the tea.^[81] For centuries, tea shoots were harvested only by hand, or "plucked," but in time workers came to use shears or sickles to speed the job, and in the twentieth century commercial plantations adopted machines for the task, especially for low-grade black teas processed by the crush, tear, curl method. Today *World Tea News* estimates that at least 70 percent of tea bushes worldwide are harvested by practices other than plucking.^[82]

Only the top 25 to 50 millimetres (1 to 2 in) of the mature plant are picked. These buds and leaves are called 'flushes'.^[83] A plant will grow a new flush every 7 to 15 days during the growing season. Leaves that are slow in development tend to produce better-flavoured teas.^[70] Several teas are available from specified flushes; for example,

Darjeeling tea is available as first flush (at a premium price), second flush, monsoon and autumn. Assam second flush or "tippy" tea is considered superior to first flush, because of the gold tips that appear on the leaves.

Pests that can afflict tea plants include mosquito bugs, genus *Helopeltis*, which are true bugs and not to be confused with dipterous insects of family *Culicidae* ('mosquitos'). Mosquito bugs can damage leaves both by sucking plant materials, and by the laying of eggs (oviposition) within the plant. Spraying with synthetic insecticides may be deemed appropriate.^[84] Other pests are Lepidopteran leaf feeders and various tea diseases.

Production

[illegible]

Tea is mainly grown in Asia and Africa, with smaller areas in South America and around the Black and Caspian Seas. The four biggest tea-producing countries are China, India, Kenya and Sri Lanka, together representing 81% of world tea production. Smaller hubs of production include such places as [São Miguel Island, Azores](#), in Portugal, and [Guria](#), in Georgia. In 2022, global production of tea was 29.8 million [tonnes](#), led by China with 49% and India with 20% of the world total. [Kenya](#), [Sri Lanka](#), and [Turkey](#) were secondary producers.^[86]

Storage

Storage conditions determine the [shelf life](#) of tea; black tea shelf life is greater than that of green teas. Some, such as flower teas, may last only a month or so. Others, such as pu-erh, improve with age. To remain fresh and prevent mold, tea needs to be stored away from heat, light, air, and moisture. Tea must be kept at room temperature in an air-tight container. Black tea in a bag within a sealed opaque canister may keep for two years. Green tea deteriorates more rapidly, usually in less than a year. Tightly rolled [gunpowder tea](#) leaves keep longer than the more open-leafed [Chun Mee tea](#).

Storage life for all teas can be extended by using [desiccant](#) or oxygen-absorbing packets, vacuum sealing, or refrigeration in air-tight containers (except green tea, where discrete use of refrigeration or freezing is recommended and temperature variation kept to a minimum).^[87]

Processing and classification

After picking, the leaves of *C. sinensis* soon begin to [wilt](#) and [oxidize](#) unless immediately dried. An [enzymatic oxidation](#) process triggered by the plant's intracellular [enzymes](#) causes the leaves to turn progressively darker as their [chlorophyll](#) breaks down and [tannins](#) are released. This darkening is stopped at a predetermined stage by heating, which deactivates the enzymes responsible. In the production of black teas, halting by heating is carried out simultaneously with drying. Without careful moisture

and temperature control during manufacture and packaging, growth of undesired molds and bacteria may make tea unfit for consumption.

Tea is divided into categories based on how it is processed.^[88] At least six different types are produced:

- **Green**: unwilted and unoxidized;
- **Yellow**: unwilted and unoxidized but allowed to yellow;
- **White**: wilted and unoxidized;
- **Oolong**: wilted, bruised, and partially oxidized;
- **Black**: wilted, sometimes crushed, and fully oxidized (called 紅茶 [*hóngchá*], "red tea" in Chinese and other East Asian tea culture);
- **Post-fermented (Dark)**: green tea that has been allowed to ferment/compost (called *Pu'er* if from the Yunnan district of South-Western China or 黑茶 [*hēichá*] "black tea" in Chinese tea culture).

Blending and additives

After basic processing, teas may be altered through additional processing steps before being sold^[89] and is often consumed with additions to the basic tea leaf and water added during preparation or drinking. Examples of additional processing steps that occur before tea is sold are blending, flavouring, scenting, and decaffeination of teas. Examples of additions added at the point of consumption include milk, sugar and lemon.

Tea blending is the combination of different teas together to achieve the final product. Such teas may combine others from the same cultivation area or several different ones. The aim is to obtain consistency, better taste, higher price, or some combination of the three.

Flavoured and scented teas are enhancements of the base tea. This can be accomplished through directly adding flavouring agents, such as ginger, cloves, mint leaves, cardamom, bergamot (found in Earl Grey), vanilla, and spearmint. Alternatively, because tea easily retains odours, it can be placed in proximity to an aromatic ingredient to absorb its aroma, as in traditional jasmine tea.^[90]

The addition of milk to tea in Europe was first mentioned in 1680 by the epistolist [Madame de Sévigné](#).^[91] Many teas are traditionally drunk with milk in cultures where dairy products are consumed. These include Indian [masala chai](#) and British tea blends. These teas tend to be very hearty varieties of black tea which can be tasted through the milk, such as Assams, or the East Friesian blend. Milk is thought to neutralise remaining tannins and reduce acidity.^{[92][93]} The [Han Chinese](#) do not usually drink milk with tea but the [Manchus](#) do, and the elite of the Qing Dynasty of the Chinese Empire continued to do so. [Hong Kong-style milk tea](#) is based on British habits. [Tibetans](#) and other Himalayan peoples traditionally drink tea with milk or [yak butter](#) and salt. In Eastern European countries, and in Russia and Italy, tea is commonly served with lemon juice. In Poland, tea is traditionally served with a slice of lemon and is sweetened with either sugar or honey; tea with milk is called a *bawarka* ("[Bavarian style](#)") in [Polish](#) and is widely popular.^[94] In Australia, tea with milk is known as "white tea".

The order of steps in preparing a cup of tea is a much-debated topic and can vary widely between cultures and individuals. Some say it is preferable to add the milk to the cup before the tea, as the high temperature of freshly brewed tea can denature the proteins found in fresh milk, similar to the change in taste of [UHT](#) milk, resulting in an inferior-tasting beverage.^[95] Others insist it is better to add the milk to the cup after the tea, as black tea is often brewed as close to boiling as possible. The addition of milk chills the beverage during the crucial brewing phase, if brewing in a cup rather than using a pot, meaning the delicate flavour of a good tea cannot be fully appreciated. By adding the milk afterwards, it is easier to dissolve sugar in the tea and to ensure the desired amount of milk is added, as the colour of the tea can be observed.^[96] Historically, the order of steps was taken as an indication of class: only those wealthy enough to afford good-quality porcelain would be confident of its being able to cope with being exposed to boiling water unadulterated with milk.^[97] Higher temperature difference means faster [heat transfer](#), so the earlier milk is added, the slower the drink cools. A 2007 study published in the *European Heart Journal* found certain [beneficial effects of tea](#) may be lost through the addition of milk.^[98]

Packaging

Tea bags

In 1907, American tea merchant Thomas Sullivan began distributing samples of his tea in small bags of silk with a drawstring. Consumers noticed they could simply leave the tea in the bag and reuse it with fresh tea. However, the potential of this distribution and packaging method would not be fully realised until later. During World War II, tea was rationed in the United Kingdom. In 1953, after [rationing in the UK](#) ended, [Yorkshire](#)-based tea manufacturer [Tetley](#) launched the tea bag in the UK, and it was an immediate success.

The "pyramid tea bag" (or sachet), introduced by Lipton^[99] and PG Tips/Scottish Blend in 1996,^[100] attempts to address one of the connoisseurs' arguments against paper tea bags by way of its three-dimensional [tetrahedron](#) shape, which allows more room for tea leaves to expand while steeping.^[101] However, some types of pyramid tea bags have been criticised as being environmentally unfriendly, since their synthetic material is not as biodegradable as loose tea leaves and paper tea bags.^[102]

Loose tea

The tea leaves are packaged loosely in a canister, paper bag, or other container such as a [tea chest](#). Some whole teas, such as rolled [gunpowder tea](#) leaves, which resist crumbling, are vacuum-packed for freshness in [aluminised packaging](#) for storage and retail. The loose tea is individually measured for use, allowing for flexibility and flavour control at the expense of convenience. Strainers, [tea balls](#), tea presses, filtered teapots, and infusion bags prevent loose leaves from floating in the tea and over-brewing. A traditional method uses a three-piece lidded teacup called a [gaiwan](#), the lid of which is tilted to decant the tea into a different cup for consumption.

Compressed tea

[Tea bricks](#) or compressed tea are produced for convenience in transport, storage, and ageing. It can usually be stored longer without spoilage than loose leaf tea.

Compressed tea is prepared by loosening leaves from the cake using a small knife, and steeping the extracted pieces in water. During the Tang dynasty, as described by Lu Yu, compressed tea was ground into a powder, combined with hot water, and ladled into bowls, resulting in a "frothy" mixture.^[103] In the [Song dynasty](#), the tea powder would instead be whisked with hot water in the bowl. Although no longer practiced in China

today, the whisking method of preparing powdered tea was transmitted to Japan by [Zen Buddhist](#) monks, and is still used to prepare [matcha](#) in the [Japanese tea ceremony](#).^[104] Chinese [pu-erh](#) is often distributed in the form, as other teas may sometimes be.

Compressed tea was the most popular form of tea in China during the Tang dynasty.^[105] By the beginning of the Ming dynasty, it had been displaced by loose-leaf tea.^[106] It remains popular, however, in the Himalayan countries and Mongolian steppes. In Mongolia, tea bricks were ubiquitous enough to be used as a form of currency. Among Himalayan peoples, compressed tea is consumed by combining it with [yak butter](#) and salt to produce [butter tea](#).^[107]

Instant tea

Main article: [Instant tea](#)

"Instant tea", similar to [freeze-dried instant coffee](#) and an alternative to brewed tea, can be consumed either hot or cold. Instant tea was developed in the 1930s, with [Nestlé](#) introducing the first commercial product in 1946, while Redi-Tea debuted instant [iced tea](#) in 1953. Additives such as [chai](#), vanilla, honey or fruit, are popular, as is [powdered milk](#).

During the Second World War British and Canadian soldiers were issued an instant tea in their composite ration ("compo") packs. These blocks of instant tea, powdered milk, and sugar were not always well received. As Royal Canadian Artillery Gunner, George C Blackburn observed:

But, unquestionably, the feature of Compo rations destined to be remembered beyond all others is Compo tea...Directions say to "sprinkle powder on heated water and bring to the boil, stirring well, three heaped teaspoons to one pint of water." Every possible variation in the preparation of this tea was tried, but...it always ended up the same way. While still too hot to drink, it is a good-looking cup of strong tea. Even when it becomes just cool enough to be sipped gingerly, it is still a good-tasting cup of tea, if you like your tea strong and sweet. But let it cool enough to be quaffed and enjoyed, and your lips will be coated with a sticky scum that forms across the surface, which if left undisturbed will become a leathery membrane that can be wound around your finger and flipped away...^[108]

Bottled and canned tea

Main article: [Canned tea](#)

Canned tea is sold prepared and ready to drink. It was introduced in 1981 in Japan. The first bottled tea was introduced by an Indonesian tea company, PT. Sinar Sosro in 1969 with the brand name Teh Botol Sosro (or Sosro bottled tea).^[109] In 1983, Swiss-based Bischofszell Food Ltd. was the first company to bottle iced tea on an industrial scale.^[110]

Tea culture

Main article: [Tea culture](#)

See also: [American tea culture](#), [Argentine tea culture](#), [Brazilian tea culture](#), [Chinese tea culture](#), [Dominican tea culture](#), [Indian tea culture](#), [Tea culture in Japan](#), [Mexican tea culture](#), [Russian tea culture](#), [Senegalese tea culture](#), and [Tea in the United Kingdom](#)

In many cultures, tea is consumed at elevated social events, such as the [tea party](#). [Tea ceremonies](#) have arisen in different cultures, such as the [Chinese](#) and [Japanese](#) traditions, each of which employs certain techniques and ritualised protocol of brewing and serving tea for enjoyment in a refined setting. One form of Chinese tea ceremony is the [Gongfu tea ceremony](#), which typically uses small [Yixing clay teapots](#) and oolong tea.

[In the United Kingdom](#), 63% of people drink tea daily.^[111] It is customary for a host to offer tea to guests soon after their arrival. Tea is consumed both at home and outside the home, often in cafés or [tea rooms](#). [Afternoon tea](#) with cakes on fine porcelain is a cultural stereotype. In southwest England, many cafés serve a [cream tea](#), consisting of scones, [clotted cream](#), and jam alongside a pot of tea.

Ireland, as of 2016, was the second-biggest per capita consumer of tea in the world, after Turkey.^[112] Local blends are the most popular in Ireland, including [Irish breakfast tea](#), using Rwandan, Kenyan and Assam teas. The annual national average of tea consumption in Ireland is 2.7 kg to 4 kg per person. [Tea in Ireland](#) is usually taken with milk or sugar and brewed longer for a stronger taste.^[113]

[Turkish tea](#) is an important part of [that country's cuisine](#) and is the most commonly consumed hot drink, despite the country's long history with coffee. In 2004, Turkey produced 205,500 tonnes of tea (6.4% of the global total), which made it one of the largest tea markets in the world,^[114] with 120,000 tons being consumed in Turkey and the rest being exported.^[115] In 2010, Turkey had the highest per capita consumption in the world at 2.7 kg.^[116] As of 2013, the per-capita consumption of Turkish tea exceeds 10 cups per day and 13.8 kg per year.^[117] Tea is grown mostly in [Rize Province](#) on the Black Sea coast.^[118]

[Russia has a long, rich tea history](#) dating to 1638 when tea was introduced to [Tsar Michael](#). Social gatherings were considered incomplete without tea, which was traditionally brewed in a [samovar](#).^[119]

In Pakistan, both black and green teas are popular and are known locally as *sabz chai* and *kahwah*, respectively. The popular green tea is often served after every meal in the [Pashtun](#) belt of [Balochistan](#) and in [Khyber Pakhtunkhwa](#). In central and southern Punjab and the metropolitan Sindh region of Pakistan, tea with milk and sugar (sometimes with pistachios, cardamom, etc.), commonly referred to as *chai*, is widely consumed. It is the most common beverage of households in the region. In the northern Pakistani regions of [Chitral](#) and [Gilgit-Baltistan](#), a salty, buttered [Tibetan-style tea](#) is consumed.

[Indian tea culture](#) is strong; the drink is the most popular hot beverage in the country. It is consumed daily^[120] in almost all houses, offered to guests, consumed in high amounts in domestic and official surroundings, and is made with the addition of milk with or without spices, and usually sweetened. It is sometimes served with biscuits to be dipped in the tea and eaten before consuming the tea. More often than not, it is drunk in "doses" of small cups (referred to as "cutting" chai if sold at street tea vendors) rather than one large cup.

[Iranians](#) have one of the highest per capita rates of tea consumption in the world. *Châikhânes* ([teahouses](#)) are common in Iran.^[121] Iranian tea is typically served in traditional Iranian glasses with a traditional saucer and teaspoon. Tea is cultivated in [northern Iran](#) along the shores of the [Caspian Sea](#).^[122]

In Burma ([Myanmar](#)), tea is consumed not only as hot drinks, but also as [sweet tea](#) and green tea known locally as *laphet-yay* and *laphet-yay-gyan*, respectively. Pickled tea leaves, known locally as [lahpet](#), are a national delicacy. Pickled tea is usually eaten with roasted sesame seeds, crispy fried beans, roasted peanuts and fried garlic chips.^[123]

In Mali, [gunpowder tea](#) is served in series of three, starting with the highest oxidation or strongest, unsweetened tea, locally referred to as "strong like death", followed by a second serving, where the same tea leaves are boiled again with some sugar added ("pleasant as life"), and a third one, where the same tea leaves are boiled for the third time with yet more sugar added ("sweet as love"). Green tea is the central ingredient of a distinctly Malian custom, the "Grin", an informal social gathering that cuts across social and economic lines, starting in front of family compound gates in the afternoons and extending late into the night, and is widely popular in [Bamako](#) and other large urban areas.^[124]

In the United States, 80% of tea is consumed as [iced tea](#).^[125] [Sweet tea](#) is native to the [southeastern U.S.](#) and is iconic in its cuisine due to its refreshing temperature and large amount of [sweetener](#).^[126]